Ram Prasad Bismil

Freedom struggle research dossier | Person | Research only | Prepared 21 October 2026

Reading note: Everything here is a research finding, not a finished story. Each stated fact below carries a link to a page opened during research and a short exact quotation. UNSURE is used where the evidence conflicts or is weak. "LATER ACCOUNT" means a report written after the event, rather than a verified contemporary record. Source labels open the original pages.

1. Basic facts

Identity, birth, death

Name: Ram Prasad Bismil (also styled Pandit Ram Prasad Bismil). | source: PIB | Exact quote: "Pt. Ram Prasad Bismil"

Pen names: Bismil, Ram and Agyat. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "Bismil', 'Ram' and 'Agyat"

Birth: 11 June 1897, Shahjahanpur, United Provinces (now Uttar Pradesh). | source: PIB | Exact quote: "born on 11th June, 1897 in Shahjahanpur"

Death: 19 December 1927 at Gorakhpur Jail. Cause: execution by hanging. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "hanged in the Gorakhpur jail on 19 December 1927"

Work: poet, writer and revolutionary organiser. | source: REK | Exact quote: "revolutionary, poet, and freedom fighter"

Family, education, and writings

Father Murlidhar and mother Moolmati. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "to Murlidhar and Moolmati"

Learnt Hindi from his father and Urdu from a local maulvi. | source: IE23 | Exact quote: "learnt Hindi from his father and Urdu from a maulvi"

Attended an English-medium school in Shahjahanpur. | source: IE23 | Exact quote: "English medium school in Shahjahanpur"

Later account says Bismil attended Mission School. | source: SEARLY | Exact quote: "Mission School in First Division"

Published poetry in Hindi and Urdu. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "poems in Urdu and Hindi"

Wrote an autobiography while imprisoned before his execution. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "While awaiting execution, Ramprasad wrote his autobiography"

UNSURE: occupation beyond writing and revolutionary activities - no independently verified steady job record from opened high-priority sources. | source: REK | Exact quote: "poet, and freedom fighter"

Groups and organisations

Arya Samaj: joined while young. | source: IE23 | Exact quote: "He joined the Arya Samaj"

Matrivedi: revolutionary grouping involved in the Mainpuri affair. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "Matrivedi' and 'Shivaji Samiti"

Hindustan Republican Association (HRA): leading revolutionary association. | source: HC | Exact quote: "Hindustan Republic Association"

Connection with Indian National Congress: attended political activities around the Lucknow session (later account). | source: SEARLY | Exact quote: "Indian National Congress of 1916"

Eight events in date order

1916 (later account): Discussed his response to Bhai Parmanand's sentence with Somdev. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "He told Swami Somadev about his vow"

1916: Sankalp says Somdev advised him to attend the Congress at Lucknow (later account). | source: SEARLY | Exact quote: "participate actively in the next Indian National Congress of 1916"

28 January 1918: Bismil published Deshvasiyon Ke Nam Sandesh (a leaflet). | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "On 28 January 1918 'Bismil' published a pamphlet titled"

1918-1919: Mainpuri revolutionary case; named as absconder by a magistrate in November 1919 (later account). | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "declared Dixit and Bismil as absconders"

By 1925: Hindustan Republican Association had produced a constitution and prospectus, later seized by investigators. | source: HC | Exact quote: "prospectus and constitution of the Hindustan Republic Association"

9 August 1925: Kakori train robbery. | source: HC | Exact quote: "train dacoity on August 9, 1925"

6 April 1927: Main Kakori trial judgment. | source: HC | Exact quote: "judgment on April 6, 1927"

19 December 1927: Execution at Gorakhpur Jail. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "on 19 December 1927"

2. Story angles

Hooks are questions, not story prose. Each entry gives the source evidence and any uncertainty.

1. The Boy with Three Languages

Hook: How did a student in Shahjahanpur learn to read across three languages?

Hindi and Urdu learning at home and from a teacher. | source: IE23 | Exact quote: "Hindi from his father and Urdu from a maulvi"

English-medium schooling. | source: IE23 | Exact quote: "English medium school in Shahjahanpur"

2. The School That Changed

Hook: Why did Bismil move between different schools?

Sankalp reports studying in Urdu and then switching school systems. | source: SEARLY | Exact quote: "he was admitted to an English school"

Evidence note: LATER ACCOUNT; school admission records not opened.

3. A Poem Called Mera Janm

Hook: What news made a teenager write a poem?

Report that the news concerned Bhai Parmanand. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "the death sentence passed on Bhai Parmanand"

Name of the poem. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "his poem ‘Mera Janm’"

Evidence note: LATER ACCOUNT; exact original poem manuscript not inspected.

4. The Book the Government Banned

Hook: What was inside a book about another country’s independence?

Sankalp records the Hindi book title. | source: SEARLY | Exact quote: "America Ki Swatantrata Ka Itihas"

Its sale was prohibited by government, says Sankalp. | source: SEARLY | Exact quote: "Government prohibited it to be sold"

Evidence note: LATER ACCOUNT; original order banning the book not opened.

5. Two Groups, Two Friends

Hook: How did Bismil and Genda Lal Dixit work with groups in different towns?

Organisations identified in newspaper account. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "‘Matrivedi’ and ‘Shivaji Samiti’"

Genda Lal was a schoolteacher. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "school teacher at Auraiya"

6. The Leaflet of January 1918

Hook: What did the revolutionaries hand out?

Pamphlet title and date recorded by Sankalp. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "Deshvasiyon Ke Nam Sandesh"

Related poem title. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "Mainpuri Ki Pratigya"

Evidence note: No verified public-domain scan of the original leaflet found.

7. The Escape into the Yamuna?

Hook: Did the police really think Bismil had disappeared beneath a river?

Later narrative describes a dive into the Yamuna. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "Bismil jumped into the river Yamuna"

Evidence note: UNSURE / LATER ACCOUNT. No contemporary police or witness record independently verified.

8. Three Signatures on Poems

Hook: Why would the same writer use different names?

Reported pen names. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "'Bismil', 'Ram' and 'Agyat'"

9. The Friends from Different Faiths

Hook: What did Bismil remember about his friendship with Ashfaqulla Khan?

A later NBT publication quotes Bismil's autobiography. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "You became my brother in a few days of friendship"

Evidence note: LATER MEMORY: Words attributed to Bismil in his autobiography; not a recorded conversation.

10. A Constitution in Seized Papers

Hook: What did investigators find written on an association's papers?

Court history records a prospectus among seized papers. | source: HC | Exact quote: "prospectus and constitution of the Hindustan Republic Association"

11. The Bag on a Train

Hook: What made revolutionaries target money carried by rail?

The trial record identifies the train. | source: HC | Exact quote: "train (8 Down) of the East Indian Railway"

The railway alarm was pulled. | source: HC | Exact quote: "pulling the communication cord"

12. The Passenger Who Died

Hook: What happened to an ordinary traveller during the Kakori robbery?

The court history records Ahmad Ali's death. | source: HC | Exact quote: "killed a lawyer Ahmad Ali"

Evidence note: This death must not be omitted or excused when researching the raid.

13. The Courtroom and the Sentence

Hook: What happened after the robbery, and who faced separate trials?

Court history records two proceedings. | source: HC | Exact quote: "tried in a supplementary trial"

Bismil's judgment date. | source: HC | Exact quote: "April 6, 1927"

14. The Safe in the Brake Van

Hook: Where was the government money kept on the Kakori train?

High Court history identifies where the railway safe was carried. | source: HC | Exact quote: "safe in the brake van"

The court history records the safe being broken open. | source: HC | Exact quote: "safe was broken open"

Evidence note: The court history describes the contents; do not invent the precise objects or tools used.

15. Pages Written Before Death

Hook: Why did Bismil write about his life while in prison?

NBT confirms he wrote his autobiography. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "Ramprasad wrote his autobiography"

Evidence note: LATER DOCUMENT HISTORY: original manuscript or colonial translation not opened.

16. A Mother's Last Visit?

Hook: What do later books say happened before the execution?

NBT dates a visit by his mother. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "On 18 December 1927"

Narrative describes the visit at Gorakhpur prison. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "mother went to Gorakhpur jail"

Evidence note: UNSURE / LATER RETELLING by R. K. Tandon; dialogue was not cross-checked against a firsthand witness record.

17. Two Writers Called Bismil

Hook: Who actually wrote Sarfaroshi Ki Tamanna?

Government Publications Division attributes it to another poet. | source: YOJ | Exact quote: "written by another poet, namely, Bismil Azimabadi"

Rekhta prints the poem under Azimabadi's name. | source: AZI | Exact quote: "Bismil Azimabadi"

Evidence note: This is a documented misattribution; the shared pen-name caused confusion.

Flagship research candidate: Angle 12, "The Passenger Who Died", alongside Angle 11, "The Bag on a Train". Reason: the court record describes the exact train, the alarm cord, the aim of taking government money, and a passenger's death. That makes it possible to investigate a widely retold event without hiding its consequences. For a quieter person-led story, Angle 9 or Angle 17 offers a stronger alternative.

3. People and places connected

Murlidhar — Bismil's father. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "Murlidhar and Moolmati"

Moolmati — Bismil's mother. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "Murlidhar and Moolmati"

Swami Somdev — religious and political teacher in the account of Bismil's youth. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "came in contact with Swami Somdev"

Bhai Parmanand — news of his death sentence is linked to Bismil's first political poetry. | source: IE23 | Exact quote: "death sentence handed out to Arya Samaj missionary Bhai Parmanand"

Genda Lal Dixit — teacher and fellow organiser during the Mainpuri affair. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "Genda Lal Dixit"

Ashfaqulla Khan — friend and fellow revolutionary. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "friendship with Ashfaq"

Rajendra Nath Lahiri — death-sentenced accused in the main trial. | source: HC | Exact quote: "Rajendra Nath Lahiri"

Roshan Singh — death-sentenced accused in the main trial. | source: HC | Exact quote: "Raushan Singh"

Sachindra Nath Bakshi — convicted in the supplementary trial. | source: HC | Exact quote: "Sachindra Nath Bakshi"

Ahmad Ali — person killed when the train was held up. | source: HC | Exact quote: "a lawyer Ahmad Ali"

Bismil Azimabadi — poet of Sarfaroshi Ki Tamanna, not Ram Prasad Bismil. | source: YOJ | Exact quote: "written by another poet, namely, Bismil Azimabadi"

Shahjahanpur — Bismil's birthplace. | source: PIB | Exact quote: "in Shahjahanpur"

Auraiya — where Dixit worked as a school teacher. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "school teacher at Auraiya"

Mainpuri — site of the earlier conspiracy investigation. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "Mainpuri Conspiracy"

Kakori, near Lucknow — train incident location. | source: HC | Exact quote: "left Kakori Railway Station"

Gorakhpur Jail — place of Bismil's execution. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "Gorakhpur jail"

4. Disputes, legends and doubts

A. Authorship of Sarfaroshi Ki Tamanna: government sources conflict

2021 government press note credits the poem to Bismil. | source: PIB | Exact quote: "he wrote 'Mera Rang De BasantiChola' and 'Sarfaroshi Ki Tamanna'"

2022 government journal instead credits Bismil Azimabadi. | source: YOJ | Exact quote: "a poem written by another poet, namely, Bismil Azimabadi"

Rekhta supports the Azimabadi attribution. | source: AZI | Exact quote: "rightful creator, Bismil Azimabadi"

Assessment: Outcome: the 2021 attribution is contradicted by the 2022 specialist government article and the poetry archive. Do not credit the poem to Ram Prasad.

B. Location where the autobiography was written

2019 Indian Express places the autobiography at Lucknow Jail. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "In Barrack number 11 of Lucknow Central Jail"

NBT associates it with awaiting execution, without a clear location in the quoted line. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "While awaiting execution, Ramprasad wrote his autobiography"

NBT identifies the prison where the sentence was carried out. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "hanged in the Gorakhpur jail on 19 December 1927"

Assessment: Outcome: UNSURE whether the manuscript was started at Lucknow, continued at Gorakhpur, or both. Original dated pages or prison logs were not inspected.

C. Where and when did Bismil first meet Ashfaqulla Khan?

NBT's Bismil chapter says the meeting was during college. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "during his college days"

NBT's Ashfaq chapter places it while they were schoolboys. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "he was studying in eighth standard"

Assessment: Outcome: UNSURE. The same published book gives accounts which are not fully compatible. Do not invent a precise first meeting.

D. Reported last words

2019 Indian Express gives a final slogan. | source: IE19 | Exact quote: "With the words "Jai Hind" on his lips"

NBT describes different slogans. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "Vande Mataram and Bharat Mata ki Jai"

Assessment: Outcome: UNSURE. No contemporaneous verbatim execution record was opened. Both are later retellings.

E. Escape into the Yamuna

Sankalp includes an underwater escape story. | source: SMAIN | Exact quote: "swam underwater"

Assessment: Outcome: UNSURE / LATER ACCOUNT by Sankalp. The incident was not independently confirmed from a police report or eyewitness testimony.

F. The mother's farewell speech

NBT dates her reported prison visit. | source: NBT | Exact quote: "just one day before his execution"

Assessment: Outcome: LATER RETELLING by R. K. Tandon, not a verified recording of their words. Do not present remembered dialogue as a verbatim transcript.

G. The Kakori train also involved a death

The High Court history names a person killed. | source: HC | Exact quote: "killed a lawyer Ahmad Ali"

Assessment: Outcome: This is not a dispute within the checked court history. It is included to prevent one-sided retelling of the incident.

H. Who founded the Hindustan Republican Association?

PIB names co-founders from a later revolutionary generation. | source: PIB | Exact quote: "with leaders like Bhagat Singh and Chandrasekhar Azad"

The court record confirms HRA papers, not that founders list. | source: HC | Exact quote: "constitution of the Hindustan Republic Association"

Assessment: Outcome: UNSURE about the precise founding circle from these quotations. Use HRA association for Bismil; do not assert a complete founder list without contemporary organisational records.

5. Pictures

Only original historical photograph files with an explicit Commons public-domain claim in both India and the United States are included. No later statues, commemorative postage stamps or reenactments are included. Commons licensing is a page-level statement, not independent proof of original authorship.

Ram Prasad Bismil portrait

File page: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:%E0%A4%AC%E0%A4%BF%E0%A4%B8%E0%A5%8D%E0%A4%AE%E0%A4%BF%E0%A4%B2901.gif

What: Old photograph identified as Bismil; original author and source unknown. **Date:** No later than 1927 **Licence on file page:** Public domain in India; PD-1996 public domain in United States.

Exact file-page text: "Date | No later than 1927"

Ashfaqulla Khan portrait

File page: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Ashfaqulla_Khan_2619.JPG

What: Old photograph of Bismil's fellow revolutionary. **Date:** Circa 1920 / 1920s (estimated) **Licence on file page:** Public domain in India; PD-1996 public domain in United States.

Exact file-page text: "An undated photo of Ashfaqulla Khan"

Ashfaqulla Khan in Faizabad Jail

File page: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Ashfaqulla_Khan_in_Faizabad_jail.jpg

What: Archival photograph labelled as Ashfaqulla Khan while in jail. **Date:** Before 1927 (Commons metadata; exact date UNSURE) **Licence on file page:** Public domain in India; PD-1996 public domain in United States.

Exact file-page text: "The photo is of Ashfaqulla Khan while he was in Faizabad jail"

Excluded from the reusable list: a Bismil portrait that lacks a US public-domain tag, modern composite memorial photographs, and images with unclear provenance or conflicting rights information. Their omission is intentional.

6. Sources used

1. **2021 note on Ram Prasad Bismil** — Press Information Bureau, Ministry of Culture, Government of India. Open original page
2. **History of the Court in Avadh: Revolutionary Conspiracy Case** — Allahabad High Court. Open original page
3. **Hanged for Patriotism: Ramprasad Bismil chapter** — National Book Trust, India (R. K. Tandon). Open original page
4. **Who is Ram Prasad Bismil...** — The Indian Express (2019). Open original page
5. **A revolutionary and a poet: Who was Ram Prasad Bismil?** — The Indian Express, Arjun Sengupta (2023). Open original page
6. **Ram Parsad Bismil: profile** — Rekhta Foundation. Open original page
7. **Literature Defying the Raj (Yojana, August 2022, page 15)** — Publications Division, Government of India. Open original page
8. **Sarfaroshi ki tamanna... (poem and attribution)** — Rekhta Foundation. Open original page
9. **Early life** — Sankalp India Foundation, Project Tiranga. Open original page
10. **Revolutionary actions in Mainpuri** — Sankalp India Foundation, Project Tiranga. Open original page
11. **Bismil901.gif (Hindi filename): Ram Prasad Bismil portrait** — Wikimedia Commons. Open original page
12. **Ashfaqulla Khan 2619.JPG: historic portrait** — Wikimedia Commons. Open original page
13. **Ashfaqulla Khan in Faizabad jail.jpg** — Wikimedia Commons. Open original page